And as far as your district (extends), dispatch ye (an officer) everywhere according to the letter of this (edict).

In the same way cause (your subordinates) to dispatch (an officer) according to the letter of this (edict) in all the territories (surrounding) forts.[59]

Several aspects of this unusual edict are worth highlighting. A royal patron and builder speaks now not as a king with Buddhist inclinations but as a Buddhist head of government. Sarnath's epigraph takes Ashoka beyond the mere practice of supporting Buddhist Shramanas and that of enlarging and building in the holy places associated with the faith. Fighting dissension within the Sangha makes him sound for the first time papal. On doctrinal and disciplinary issues, as few as nine dissenting monks could be fissiparous, suggesting the high possibility of upheaval even during the Buddha's lifetime.[60] Ashoka seems opposed to the ease with which factional breakaways have been happening and proposes to punish dissidents by forcing them to give up their monastic robes and take on the white clothes ('avadatavasana') of householders. Whether this came to be enforced is not known; the existence of groups and sub-groups within the Buddhist faith in ancient India suggests that schisms of the kind which bothered Ashoka were common enough. What is extraordinary is that the emperor seems to have displaced senior monks and councils of monks who would normally discourage factional breaks. Ashoka wants his administration to ensure wide circulation of the proscription: a copy was to be submitted to the Sangha, the laity was to be inspired by it on every fast day (every fortnight, most likely), and mahamatras were ordered to retain a copy so that they too could be similarly inspired.